

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in the opinion page of a newspaper in Hong Kong:

Helper idea easier said than done

The Hong Kong Government is looking at giving elderly people who live alone in public housing up to HK\$8,000 a month to employ domestic helpers from overseas to look after them and help reduce the costs of providing care homes for the elderly.

The idea seems simple, and could be done by expanding the current community care service voucher for the elderly. But unfortunately, it isn't that easy.

For the elderly, receiving the subsidy would only mark the beginning of a long list of hassles they would find difficult to handle, unless the government was committed to help them every step of the way. That would include assisting them in the hiring of a helper and paying regular visits – and I mean weekly, not once every few months – to ensure everything is going smoothly.

And when two adults stay together, sharing an extremely small public housing unit designed for use by one, won't problems arise over time due to the crowded space?

The results could be deadly if the relationship between the elderly person and helper goes terribly wrong.

A sensible alternative is for those who have no family support and are unable to live independently to reside in dedicated homes for the elderly.

Instead of investing in the subsidies, wouldn't it make better sense to use the money to improve existing facilities or build new ones, and employ staff trained to look after the residents 24 hours a day, seven days a week?

Your school social worker wants you to discuss whether the proposal to provide a domestic helper for all elderly people who live alone in public housing is a good idea. Your group is meeting to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- why the government suggested the idea
- the advantages and disadvantages of the idea
- any other ways to help elderly people who live alone
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you like to work with elderly people?
2. Is Hong Kong a good place for elderly people?
3. What activities could make elderly people enjoy their day?
4. Does Hong Kong help elderly people enough?
5. Should elderly people live with their families?
6. Is loneliness a big problem in Hong Kong?
7. Which is a better option for the elderly: to live alone or in a care home?
8. What is the most difficult thing for elderly people to deal with?